



Colour MFDs

Companies are facing a problem when it comes to printers and MFDs because most people don't need them anymore. Photos are shared on tablets, tickets via SMS, paper has no value. To compensate for that, we're now seeing printers pop up with facebook and twitter integration, Wi-Fi and cloud printing support and much more. Why you would want to access Facebook from a printer is beyond us but that's beside the point. MFDs now want to be an extension of our digital lives, a transitory link between the analogue and digital world that will seamlessly link our devices to our printers without the earlier "hassles" of configuring drivers on our PCs. We're seeing more and more printers that are perfectly fine as stand-alone devices that can interact directly with your tablet or smartphone.

Other than this attempt at seamless integration, we've not seen anything new from this category other than maybe Epson's ink tank design that we've spoken about in the section on monochrome MFDs.

Zero1 Winner

HP Deskjet InkAdvantage 6525

If image quality is what floats your boat, this is the MFD for you. The 6525 features what is easily the best print quality among all the devices we received, and by a wide margin no less. What was even more startling was the print quality in our text copy test, where a plaintext document was scanned and printed. The quality of the output was so good that we couldn't differentiate between a print of the original and the facsimile.



Brother J6250DW

Price: ₹11,920



EPSON L355

Price: ₹16,000

The one area where this printer really lost out was in our OCR tests. The sample we used was admittedly a tough one and few MFDs actually did well, but on a comparative scale, the HP performed half as well as the rest of the competition. Regardless, this MFD aced every one of our text print tests and was able to pump out sharp text at almost all the font sizes that we use in our point-size tests. The device comes with integrated Wi-Fi connectivity and features HP ePrint support as well as the ability to scan and e-mail images directly from the device itself, among other things. This is definitely a great printer and while the scan quality may not be stellar, it's more than adequate for SOHO use.

Worthy Mentions

Brother J6250DW

The first thing that stikes you about this MFD is how professional it looks. Now we know that's not a criteria for measuring performance or awarding our Zero1 awards, but a snappy dresser is always noticeable regardless of what else he does. The printer is relatively compact and light, but is a great performer nonetheless. The text prints were legible and sharp and so were the colour prints. The image quality was a just a little sub-par when compared to other photo-printers, but it's good enough that the average person won't notice the difference.

Another point to note about this MFD was its speed; the scan speed was the fastest we've encountered so far (at 300dpi) and even the print speed was quite good. The speeds are nowhere near that of laser printers, but they're close enough.

EPSON L355

While everyone else was busy working on improving technology, Epson snuck in with their ink tanks. These printers are great for one reason and one reason alone, price. The print quality is strictly passable and filling up the ink-tanks is a really messy business. Thankfully, that's all we have to say against the L355. The print speed was about average and the scan quality was decent, nothing to write home about, but when it comes to running costs, that's where this MFD shines. The ink refills cost almost nothing and the cost of ownership is barely ₹5 per page, half that of most other printers in the category. No matter which way you cut it, this printer is cheap to run. Sure, the output seems a tiny bit blurry and some might even argue that the build quality isn't too great, but when you're looking for an office printer that will churn out colour prints at low rates, look no further than the L355.



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